

A Hard Road TO PEACE

As prospects for talks with a significantly weakened ULFA brighten, a split in the militant outfit could well derail a peace in the making for this battered state

| By Kaushik Dekha |

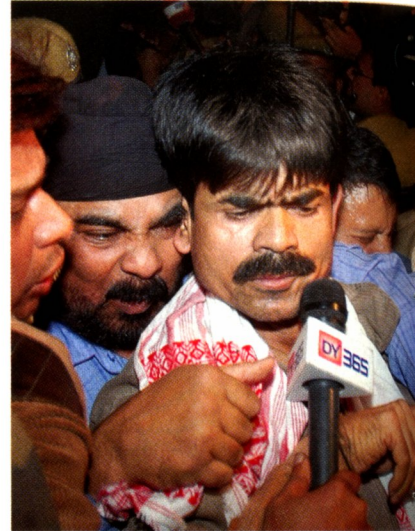
Hriday Choudhury, 38, from Bhalaguri village near Pathshala in Assam, is getting restless. He wants the army camp near his village to move from there as soon as possible. "Every night while returning home after work, the army jawans stop me and ask the same questions," says Choudhury, who now thinks that the start of a dialogue between the banned United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) and the Government will finally end his ordeal. But like many others, his patience is also wavering: will there ever be a meaningful dialogue with the militant organisation?

The hope for peace rose with the news of the arrest of top three ULFA leaders—chairman Arabinda Rajkhowa, foreign secretary Sashadhar Choudhury and finance secretary

Chitrabon Hazarika—in November last year in Bangladesh. But even after their arrest, neither the Government nor the ULFA leadership have come forward with a clear roadmap for talks. The still absconding ULFA commander-in-chief Paresh Barua is adamant that the outfit will come for talks only when sovereignty is included in the agenda, a demand that virtually kills the chances of a peace process as no government would ever agree to it. The only other possibility is that Barua is ignored by the central committee of ULFA—eight members of this body are in Guwahati jail now—and go ahead for talks, which would result in another division of the outfit.

Recent developments, however, suggest that Barua is actually waging a lone battle and the Government has been successful in breaking the group once again. "If they convey their for-

Photographs by GITIKA TAL JANDAR



mal willingness in a letter, talks will be held with due honour and dignity," said Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi. But the ULFA leaders refused to send such a letter from jail, to which Union Home Secretary G.K. Pillai said talks can be held without a letter too. Many saw it as a lack of coordination between the Centre and the state, though it was a smart tactic by the Government to show the public that it was ready to go to any extent for peace.

An outsmarted Rajkhowa said, "The situation for talks has not been created. There is no progress. Had there been any, would you still find us in jail?" To this, Gogoi said once the

INTERVIEW | KAVERI KACHARI RAJKONWAR

"An independent Assam is still possible"

Forty-two-year-old Kaveri Kachari Rajkonwar, wife of Arabinda Rajkhowa, chief of ULFA, spoke to INDIA TODAY. Excerpts:

Q. Why did you join ULFA?

A. I was impressed with the bold steps ULFA took to safeguard the rights of the exploited Assamese population.

Q. Do you think an independent

Assam is possible?

A. Yes, of course.

Q. Can talks be held without inclusion of sovereignty in the agenda?

A. Yes, they can be. All I want is peace to return to Assam. ULFA must respect the public sentiment.

Q. How was your life in Bangladesh?

A. Terrible. We moved to Dhaka after

